to solve the China problem is to ‘gang up’ on China.” He asserted that he neither had illusions about Beijing nor would he excuse its actions, but “all Asia must eventually move forward together.” In words that echoed those of Nehru two decades before, Nixon highlighted the danger of “trying to isolate China.” The president indeed said that he believed Gandhi shared this view, which they had discussed when Nixon had visited Delhi as a private citizen in 1967. Toward the end of July 1969, the briefing book for Nixon’s trip to India emphasized the importance of discussing China with his Indian interlocutors. During that visit, the subject did arise, with Kissinger telling Indian officials that the US was “open to contacts” and had made some “symbolic moves” toward China.[18]

There were other hints of a potential change in the US attitude toward China. On tour in Asia in August, Rogers publicly suggested a more conciliatory US approach. American officials noticed that Indian opinion leaders were publicly speculating about potential rapprochement. Indeed, pro-Soviet “propagandists occasionally raised the bogey of a Washington-Peking axis.” Pakistan’s potential role as a channel to China was not entirely a secret in South Asia, with Pakistani newspapers quoting American and Indian news reports that Nixon, on his visit to the subcontinent, would ask Pakistan “to play … conciliator between China and the US.”[19]

Any Sino-US rapprochement, a US interagency assessment indicated, would likely elicit two “competing” reactions in noncommunist Asia. Some in those countries, who thought Washington’s existing China policy was “totally unrealistic” and only increased the likelihood of war, would “welcome” a rapprochement. Others would “fear” it, assuming that this meant the US was “withdrawing from Asia.”[20] Both sentiments were evident in India, including in Gandhi’s public contention as early as February 1969 that US “recognition of China as a world power might be helpful in creating a new environment in Asia. But that would still leave the question of what to do with their power.”[21] The persistent Chinese threat meant Delhi was concerned about potential American withdrawal and subsequent Chinese dominance in Asia. But with Gandhi’s parallel attempts to engage China underway, this concern was balanced with understanding.

India’s Views of China and the US